

offer instant gratification which is why many newbies dabbling in games for the first time start here. Shooters can be of a number of types depending on the type of action and tactics employed, or even the camera angle.

FPS (First Person Shooter):

The most popular type. Characterised by combat from the perspective of the player—as if you are holding the weapon. The best graphics and the most action are generally found in this genre. Some shining examples are *Crysis*, *Far Cry*, *Prey*, *Doom 3* and *F.E.A.R.*

TPS (Third Person Shooter):

These shooters usually take a “behind the shoulder” view to deliver a slightly more cinematic (if less realistic) view to the action. They usually have slightly deeper storylines and a little less violence than FPSes, but this is no hard rule. *Grand Theft Auto 3* (GTA 3), *GTA San Andreas*, *Manhunt* and the *Max Payne* games are examples.

Tactical Shooter:

These are based on either FPS or TPS camera angles, but offer the additional element of stealth. A tactical shooter could also be a squad-based action game where you work with a team to, say, take down a group of terrorists. The best examples of stealth-based tactical shooters are the *Splinter Cell* series, and the *Metal Gear Solid* series. For squad based tactical shooters, *G.R.A.W.*, the *Delta Force* series and the *Rainbow Six* series are the best examples.

Shoot ‘em Ups:

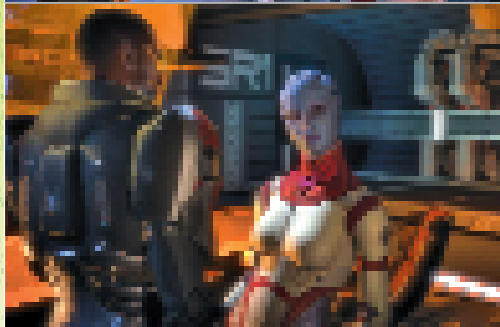
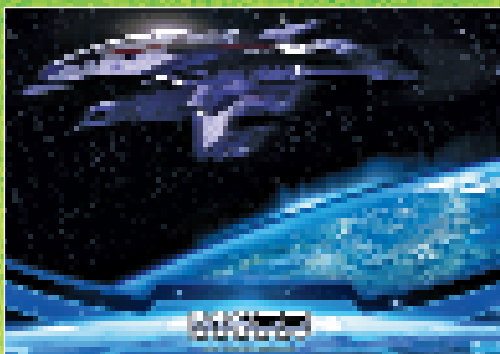
Games like the *Serious Sam* series simply have one objective—fun. Just shoot anything that moves.

RTS (Real Time Strategy)

Although the RTS genre is as diverse as Shooters, most RTS games have one thing in common—use resources to build up an economy and gradually build structures of different sorts which give you certain benefits like additional units or technology research options. Then build up an army, and attack. RTS games can be very slow or lightning fast. Some strategy games are turn-based as opposed to real-time, where you make a move and wait for the enemy to move (somewhat like chess). For example,



All RPGs will have some sort of points system, where you get to level up, thereby increasing your character's skills—for example, a warrior may be able to perform new moves, or a wizard may be able to cast new spells



Warhammer, the *Civilization* series and the *Warlords* series are legendary turn-based games. RTS games tend to be a little faster paced, since you actually build, expand and defend in real time. Examples are *Warcraft 3*, *Company Of Heroes*, *Age of Empires* and *Warhammer 40,000*.

RPG (Role Playing Games)

Traditionally, an RPG will have you playing the game as an adventurer of sorts. There are usually classes of characters like wizards, barbarians, bards, rogues and so on, but the classes and the skills that each class has depends on the story's setting. Typically, an RPG tries to create a believable world out of fantasy settings, and you are an individual in that world, living, traveling, eating, sleeping, adventuring, fighting and so on. All RPGs will have some sort of points system, where you get to level up, thereby increasing your character's skills—for example, a warrior may be able to perform new moves, or a wizard may be able to cast new spells. *Neverwinter Nights*, *The Witcher*, *Knights of the Old Republic*, *Mass Effect*, and *Hellgate London* are some of the better known RPGs around.

Vehicle Simulation

This is another wide genre, as it could involve a multitude of vehicles from cars, aeroplanes and motorbikes, to fighter aircraft, battle tanks, and even spaceships. Such games can be very serious, simply fun, or somewhere in between. The most common of the vehicle simulators are car racing games—cars are something everyone can relate to. Games like Microsoft's *Flight Simulator* accurately depict flying an aeroplane, while the *Colin McRae* series have you racing in rallies with realism. Games like the *NFS (Need For Speed)* series are fun, with hardly any deep simulative nature.

Arcade Fighters

These games usually have you as a combatant in a series of fights against a single opponent or a multitude of other combatants. You will have an array of special moves and powers to aid you, like

being able to shoot fireballs from your hands. Games like *Mortal Combat*, *Art of Fighting*, and even classics like *Contra* and *Spartan* fall into this genre.

There are a whole lot of other genres like sports games (football, basketball, tennis, etc.), music based games (want to be a rock star? Play *Guitar Hero*), puzzle solving games, and other fun games like pinball which don't really fit into any specific genre.

So now, let's take a look at your two major options:

PC Gaming: A Window Seat To The Action

How can I not sound biased when I say that I've always been a fan of the computer? Its unmatched flexibility is the key—learn on it, send e-mails, work, listen to music, surf the Internet, watch movies—the PC has something for everyone. It's shockingly adept at each of these tasks, and far from the jack of all trades that it may sometimes appear to be. While consoles cannot even dream of approaching the functionality that the PC offers, they do have one very noteworthy advantage where gaming

The best visual treatment, graphics, effects and realism are often found in this genre. Not to mention the most realistic, visceral action. PC gaming's worst proponent will agree when that consoles suck at FPSes. They require accuracy and precision while wielding weapons that only a good mouse can provide.

RTSes and RPGs also play best on a PC—this is mainly due to the fact that both these genres have a lot of environment interaction, or even group control of characters or units. Most RTS and RPG games also have a lot of sticky key shortcuts (such as [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [E]) or some other combination, which you simply cannot execute on a console. Most of these games have been designed for the PC, and console versions remain poor ports. Some of the best RTS games like *Company Of Heroes*, *Warcraft 3*, *Age Of Empires* and *Warhammer 40000* all have strong roots in the PC, on which they play the best.

Of course, the PCs forte has been customisability. A variety of keyboards and mice are available specifically for gaming—



LAN, gaming mice are worth a cursory look (at least). My advice is to skip the keyboard unless you really plan to take your gaming seriously—a regular multimedia keyboard will suffice. Note that the mouse is more important for nearly all genres of games than the keyboard, so choose one carefully.

Visually speaking, the PC also delivers the best visual experience. Of course you need a modestly powerful rig, but with the right components, the graphics on a PC will blow consoles out of the water—though the X360 and PS3 have bridged the gap, there's still a decent way to go before con-



is concerned—they were designed specifically from the ground up for that purpose. The X360 and PS3 also have limited Web surfing and movie-watching potential, which simply means that their manufacturers are trying to bring them closer to their competitor...

Games People Play

Computers reign supreme for games of the FPS, RTS and RPG genres. They also match consoles for TPSs and many adventure games, sometimes even overshadowing them. With one or two shining exceptions, the moment you say First Person Shooter, I'll happily point you towards a PC.

Logitech's G15, Microsoft's Reclusa and Razer's Tarantula are gaming keyboards designed to make the overall gaming experience more fun. Such keyboards have a number of additional features like extra configurable buttons, macro keys (keys that can store multiple keystrokes and useful for executing combos in arcade fighting games) and backlit keys (for gaming sans illumination). Mice like Razer's Lachesis, Copperhead and Logitech's G5 and G9 will leaving opponents quaking (no pun!) in their boots.

Whether you're playing your first FPS or starting up a *Quake 3* frag-fest with your friends on a

soles get to where current-generation PC graphics are.

Hardware Requirements

When talking PC, the ugly issue of the “hardware upgrade curve” usually surfaces. Computers aren't exactly easy on your wallet once you try to get them game-ready, and the process of converting a PC into a gaming rig can be expensive! Once you start building a PC for gaming, there's virtually no end to the expenses you can face, and you will also need to save up for at least one upgrade per year!

For the biggest gains keep this order in mind:

1. Graphics Card: This is the

The graphics card is the primary component for gaming, and upgrading it will yield the biggest performance gain